the lower Gangetic plains. The fear of the kaalapani began to wane. If the legend of the kaalapani promised the loss of caste upon return, this was precisely what the lower castes wanted and served to prompt them to experiment with overseas migration. Thus, from the middle of the 19th century, there was a distinct shift that occurred in overseas migration volumes as Indians began to move through indenture and more so, for adventure.

Between 1850 and 1910, overseas migration surged, powered by globalization and the steamboats, taking the size of the Indian diaspora to over 2 million people, or close to 1 per cent of the Indian population. As Table 1 at the end of this chapter shows, in 1910, nearly two-thirds of the Indian diaspora was located in Asia itself, mainly in the regions of present-day Sri Lanka, Myanmar and Malaysia. A fifth of the diaspora was based in Mauritius, South Africa and East Africa, though migration to Mauritius had tapered off by then. While all these regions were associated with the British Empire, Indians from the French colonies of India went to French-ruled territories such as Réunion Island, some 200 km southwest of Mauritius in the Indian Ocean. Around 10 per cent of the Indian diaspora was based in Latin America and the Caribbean Islands, in regions of present-day Trinidad and Tobago, Guyana and Suriname. Europe and North America attracted students, but restrictive immigration laws ensured that the Indians were kept out. Since the 1870s, the Pacific island of Fiji also rose to prominence as a destination.

Between 1910 and 1930, the diaspora rose by a million, mainly due to migration towards South East Asia, but not much changed otherwise. By then, Indian communities had begun to settle down in many places and natural growth, more than migration, mattered to their demography. In the next five decades, the collapse of the British Empire, decolonization and return migration led to a tectonic shift in the composition of the Indian diaspora away from Myanmar and Sri Lanka—two regions covered in other chapters of this book—and towards new destinations that had opened up in Britain, North America and Canada after the relaxation of immigration laws there. This migration wave consisted of professionals, instead of labourers,